1) Executive Summary & Context

The Graduate is a premium champagne brand designed exclusively for South African Gen Z graduates. It positions itself as the celebratory drink for milestone moments: graduation ceremonies, first job offers, promotions, and social lifestyle occasions. With a bold gold and black identity, the brand signals empowerment, sophistication, and youthful prestige.

Market Opportunity:
South Africa's Gen Z graduate population is entering the workforce with strong aspirations, an appetite for status-driven experiences, and heavy reliance on digital culture. They value lifestyle branding, authenticity, and social sharing. Current luxury champagne brands (Veuve, Dom Pérignon, Moët) dominate in exclusivity but lack tailored engagement with student/graduate communities. *The Graduate* bridges this gap by offering an aspirational yet approachable brand built around milestone celebrations and peer-to-peer influence.

Competitive Landscape:
The champagne market in SA is defined by global luxury houses with entrenched prestige. However, their outreach remains skewed towards older, affluent consumers and formal occasions. *The Graduate* differentiates by being the first champagne brand designed for the graduate journey, using activations at universities, malls, networking events, festivals, and student accommodations to build cultural relevance. Social media, influencer collaborations, and UGC campaigns will drive buzz and virality, where Gen Z lives.

Core Objectives:

- Build strong awareness and brand equity with Gen Z graduates in four key provinces (Limpopo, Gauteng, Kwa-Zulu Natal and Cape Town) over six months.
- Drive product trial via campus activations, event sponsorships, and experiential sampling.
- Position *The Graduate* as the champagne of choice for milestone celebrations, outpacing traditional luxury competitors in youth engagement.
- Amplify digital reach through hashtags, influencers, and social competitions to create a self-sustaining online buzz.

2) Situational Analysis

PESTLE

Political & Economic
South Africa's luxury market is expanding, driven by a growing aspirational youth and high-net-worth individuals, personal luxury retail is projected to grow by 7% from 2022 to 2027 (Vogue Business, 2024). However, economic volatility like inflation and load-shedding-adds structural risks to strategic planning (Vogue Business, 2024).

Social
SA Gen Z is highly value-oriented: 82% will pay more for brands that make a positive societal impact, 78% for sustainability (InSites/Adcomm, 2022). They prioritize authenticity, inclusivity, and brand social responsibility (Van den Bergh et al., 2022). They define self-expression

through purchasing choices, spending as much on clothing as rent, and emphasizing image as social currency (Bizcommunity, 2025).

Technological
Gen Z's digital fluency shapes their purchasing journey. They mainly discover luxury through social media, prefer UGC and creator-led content, and trust peer validation (FashionNetwork via TikTok study, 2025).

Legal
Alcohol marketing in South Africa is regulated under the Liquor Act of 2003, demanding strict age compliance and responsible messaging in activations.

Environmental
Luxury consumption is being redefined by Gen Z. They seek experiences over ownership, with 84% favouring in-store experiences and immersive activations (FashionNetwork, 2025). De-linearized luxury-emotional, sensory, and experiential-is becoming the norm (FashionNetwork, 2025).

SWOT Analysis

Strengths • Targeted aspiration: first champagne brand aimed at Gen Z graduates, aligning with their values of experience, authenticity, and sustainability (Van den Bergh et al., 2022; FashionNetwork, 2025). • Relatable luxury: accessible prestige and social currency rather than distant opulence. • Experiential first activations (campus, mall, events) tap into Gen Z's preference for lived, shareable moments.	**Weaknesses** • Budget constraints (R100K) challenge multi-province reaches and frequency. • New market entry with low initial brand awareness against entrenched global luxury brands. • Regulatory complexity around alcohol sampling, especially in legal and student environments.
Opportunities • Rising luxury appetite among youth; SA's aspirational consumers are increasingly embracing status-driven premium • consumption (Vogue Business, 2024) • Gen Z's value-driven spending and community alignment offer openings for brand activism and social storytelling (Van den Bergh et al., 2022). • The shift toward experiential luxury and social discovery favors	**Threats** • Economic headwinds (cost-of-living, power crises) may limit discretionary spending and experiential budget • Established luxury players maintain cultural prestige, challenging newcomer memorability. • Gen Z's skepticism and low brand loyalty require genuinely differentiated brand engagement.

community-focused, digital-first brands (FashionNetwork, 2025; TikTok insights)	

Competitor Benchmarking

Brand	Market Positioning	Target Audience	Price Range (750ml)	Key Marketing Initiatives	Competitive Advantage
Moët & Chandon	Premium luxury with global recognition; accessible prestige.	Affluent professionals, celebrators.	R1,000 - R1,500	Celebrity endorsements, exclusive events, global brand presence.	Strong brand heritage and global recognition.
Veuve Clicquot	Sophisticated luxury with a focus on boldness and innovation.	Trend-conscious individuals, entrepreneurs.	R1,200 - R1,800	Bold Woman Award, collaborations with fashion and lifestyle brands.	Emphasis on empowering women and innovative marketing.
Dom Pérignon	Ultra-premium, limited edition, collector's item.	High-net-worth individuals, collectors.	R4,000 - R10,000+	Limited releases, high-profile events, partnerships with luxury brands.	Exclusivity and prestige; appeals to collectors.
The Graduate	Accessible luxury celebrating milestones and achievements.	Gen Z graduates, young professionals.	R800 - R1000	Campus activations, influencer partnerships, social media campaigns highlighting personal achievements.	Focus on inclusivity and celebrating personal milestones.

3) Target Market Definition & Personas

Demographic Segmentation

- **Age**: 21-28 (undergraduate, recent graduate, post-graduate or alumni).
- **Gender**: All genders, with gender-fluid inclusivity.
- **Income**: Middle-class to aspirational (R7,000-R25,000 monthly disposable income for recent graduates).
- **Geography**: Urban/metropolitan centers with strong graduate population ; Johannesburg, Pretoria, Durban, Cape Town, Stellenbosch, Polokwane.

Psychographic Segmentation

- Value prestige but want it to feel attainable and relevant.
- Aspirational: view milestones like graduation, first job, and social events as moments worth celebrating.
- Motivated by experiences, community, and belonging, see luxury consumption as a way of signaling achievement and identity (Van den Bergh et al., 2022).
- Socially conscious: favour brands that reflect authenticity, inclusivity, and sustainability (Sithole, 2024).

Behavioural Segmentation

- Purchase behaviour: Occasional luxury buyers (special events, peer gatherings, curated nightlife).
- Media habits: High engagement with TikTok, Instagram Reels, Twitter (X), and YouTube for lifestyle inspiration.
- Consumption drivers: Word-of-mouth, influencers, campus buzz, and digital virality.
- Brand loyalty: Low; loyalty must be earned through consistent experiences and cultural relevance.

Target Market Definition

The Graduate targets South African Gen Z graduates (ages 21–28) who are ambitious, digitally native, and socially expressive. They seek prestige that is relatable and celebratory, aligning with milestones such as graduations, first jobs, and career networking events. They prefer luxury that feels young, inclusive, and shareable.

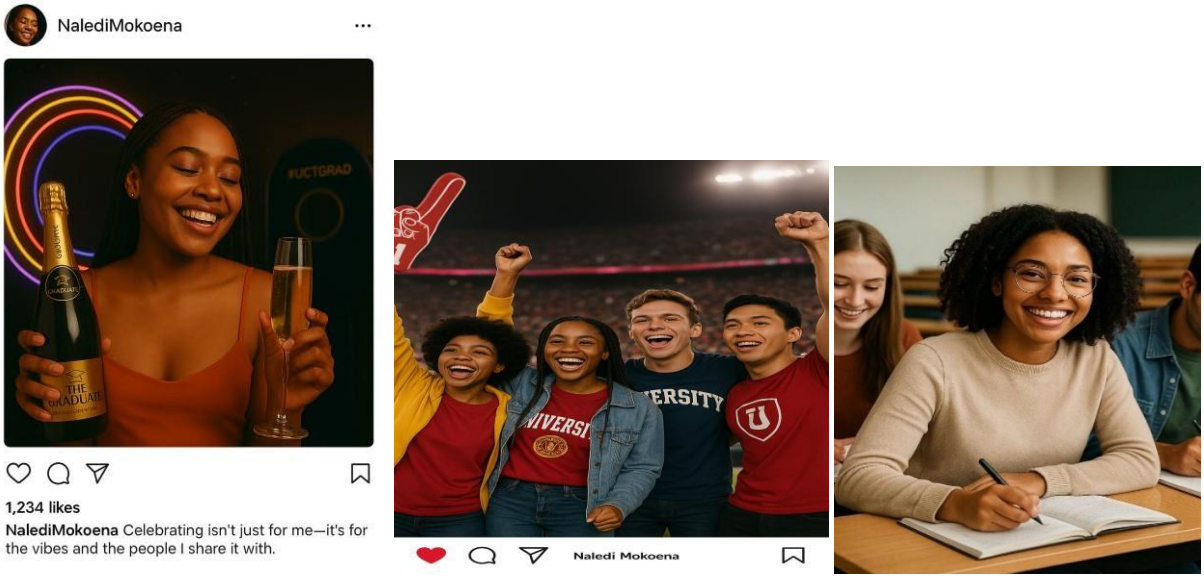
Buyer Personas

Persona 1: The Celebratory Achiever



Persona Attribute	Details
Name	**Cassey Sengwane**
Age	26
Location	Johannesburg, Braamfontein
Background	Born in rural Limpopo; graduated from UJ with a BSc in Construction Management; currently interning in Sandton while pursuing postgraduate studies.
Psychographics	Ambitious, goal-oriented, socially driven, creative, proud of achievements.
Media Habits	During his free time he enjoys listening to the radio, to keep up with the latest news and listen to conversations.
Behaviour	Purchases champagne for milestones (graduation, birthdays, new job). Choose brands that elevate social status. Enjoys following construction enthusiasts for inspiration.
Aspirations	Professional success, lifestyle upgrades, recognition for hard work.
Quote	"*I've worked hard for this. When I celebrate, I want everyone to know it.*"

Persona 2: The Social Butterfly



Persona 2: The Social Butterfly

Persona Attribute	Details
Name	Naledi Mokoena
Age	22
Location	Cape Town
Background	Final-year student at UCT, actively involved in student clubs.
Psychographics	Outgoing, sociable, expressive; values celebrations as bonding moments; sustainability-conscious and prefers brands that "do good."
Media Habits	TikTok (lifestyle influencers, music), Instagram Reels (events, social sharing).
Behaviour	Hosts and attends gatherings; curates social experiences; enjoys photobooths and branded hashtags; drawn to playful yet elegant brands.
Aspirations	Building meaningful connections, aligning with socially responsible brands, curating memorable moments.
Quote	*"Celebrating isn't just for me – it's for the vibes and the people I share it with."*



Persona 3: The Digital Tastemaker

Persona Attribute	Details
Name	Aisha Zulu
Age	24
Location	Durban
Background	Recently graduated from UKZN; runs a small online fashion side hustle.
Psychographics	Trend-driven, creative, brand-conscious; enjoys content creation and being the trendsetter in her circle.
Media Habits	TikTok (challenges and trending sounds), Instagram (aesthetic feeds), YouTube (vlogs and lifestyle).
Behaviour	Purchases premium drinks as lifestyle props for parties, photobooths, and luxury "flex" moments. Shares every experience online.
Aspirations	To grow her influence, merge lifestyle with entrepreneurship, and build a stylish, aspirational personal brand.
Quote	*"If it's not on my socials, did it even happen?"*

4) Strategic Marketing Objectives (SMART)

The strategic marketing objectives for *The Graduate* are designed to drive brand growth, awareness, engagement, and preference among South African Gen Z graduates over a six-month campaign period. First, the campaign aims to increase brand awareness by leveraging

targeted campus and social media activations to make *The Graduate* a recognizable celebratory champagne brand. Success will be measured through online surveys, social media mentions, and hashtag engagement, with a target of a 30% increase in brand awareness within the campaign period.

Second, the campaign seeks to drive social media engagement and user-generated content by encouraging graduates to share their celebratory moments using branded hashtags such as #AddADegree and #TheGraduateMoment on platforms like TikTok, Instagram, and Twitter. Engagement goals include generating over 5,000 user-generated posts, 20,000 likes, comments, and shares, and achieving 50,000 hashtag impressions. This objective will be supported through influencer partnerships, photobooths at campus and mall activations, and social media competitions, amplifying peer-to-peer promotion critical for Gen Z adoption.

Third, the campaign focuses on boosting trial and conversion through experiential marketing. Sampling activations will be conducted at 10 universities, 12 high-traffic malls, and two sponsored graduate networking events to encourage first-time purchases. The goal is to distribute over 2,500 sample units and achieve a 15% conversion rate to purchase, ensuring that experiential touchpoints translate into brand credibility and word-of-mouth growth.

Fourth, *The Graduate* aims to establish influencer partnerships for brand advocacy by collaborating with three South African Gen Z influencers to create authentic branded content. These partnerships are projected to generate 200,000 combined reach impressions, 25,000 engagements, and at least 1,000 conversion clicks to the online purchase page or promotional campaign. Influencer advocacy leverages peer trust, which is essential for this audience.

Finally, the campaign seeks to achieve brand preference over competitors such as Moët, Veuve Clicquot, and Dom Pérignon by positioning *The Graduate* as the go-to celebratory brand for Gen Z graduates. This objective will be measured through post-campaign survey research, targeting a 25% brand preference within the audience. Differentiation will be established through brand values emphasizing empowerment, accessibility, inclusivity, experiential luxury, and the celebration of personal milestones.

5) Brand Positioning & Value Proposition

The Graduate is positioned as an accessible luxury champagne brand that celebrates milestones, achievements, and youthful success, designed specifically for South African Gen Z graduates. Unlike traditional luxury champagne brands that emphasize heritage, exclusivity, and aspirational wealth, *The Graduate* emphasizes personal accomplishment, empowerment, and social celebration. It merges the prestige of premium champagne with a culturally relevant, experiential, and social-first approach that resonates with young adults entering the next phase of their lives.

The brand promise is clear: *“Celebrate every milestone with boldness, style, and confidence.”* This promise communicates both the emotional and functional benefits of the brand. It is not just a champagne, it is a symbol of achievement, social connection, and self-expression. Gen Z consumers are drawn to brands that allow them to express their individuality, share memorable experiences, and participate in inclusive celebrations, and *The Graduate* delivers on all these fronts.

The brand personality is a blend of luxury, confidence, and youthful sophistication. Its tone is playful, aspirational, stylish, and sociable, reflecting the lifestyle and values of the Gen Z graduate: bold yet approachable, celebratory yet meaningful. The brand identity uses black and gold colour schemes to signify prestige, elegance, and exclusivity, while the marketing messaging leverages youth-centric phrases such as “Add a Degree” and “Your Moment, Your Champagne” to create immediate recognition and cultural relevance.

The value proposition for *The Graduate* centers on three pillars:

1. Emotional Value – Provides graduates with a tangible way to celebrate personal achievements and milestones in a socially shareable, aspirational manner.
2. Functional Value – Delivers premium-quality champagne at an accessible price point (R800-1000) tailored to young adults entering the luxury segment.
3. Experiential Value – Creates memorable, immersive experiences through campus activations, mall events, photobooths, and social media campaigns, fostering community and word-of-mouth promotion.

By positioning itself as the celebratory choice for Gen Z graduates, *The Graduate* establishes a strong differentiation from traditional luxury champagne brands, aligning closely with the aspirations, digital habits, and social values of its target audience. This positioning ensures that every interaction-whether online, at an event, or in retail-reinforces the brand’s promise of empowerment, prestige, and shared celebration.

6) Marketing Strategy (Marketing Mix) & Big Idea

The marketing strategy for *The Graduate* is built around a holistic, experiential, and socially driven approach, designed to resonate with South African Gen Z graduates. The strategy integrates the marketing mix (Product, Price, Place, Promotion) with innovative activations and culturally relevant touchpoints, creating a unified campaign experience.

Big Idea: *“Add a Degree - Celebrate Your Moment”*

This creative concept embodies the essence of achievement, self-expression, and social celebration. Every activation, digital interaction, and influencer collaboration reinforces the idea that *The Graduate* is not just champagne, it is a symbolic companion for personal milestones, shared experiences, and aspirational celebrations. This Big Idea positions the brand as bold, accessible, and socially relevant, ensuring it resonates with Gen Z’s first digital, experience-driven lifestyle.

Marketing Mix

Product:
The Graduate is a premium yet accessible champagne brand, presented in elegant black-and-gold packaging to signify sophistication and prestige. Product offerings include standard 750ml bottles and limited-edition celebratory packs that encourage personalization and shareable experiences. The product experience is enhanced through sampling activations, photobooths,

and experiential events that allow Gen Z consumers to immerse themselves in the brand's celebratory narrative.

Price:
The brand is strategically priced at R800, positioning it as affordable luxury for students and young professionals. Pricing balances accessibility with prestige, ensuring the product feels aspirational without being unattainable. Special bundle promotions during campus and mall activations, as well as limited time offers, further incentivize purchase and trial.

Place:
The campaign leverages multi-channel distribution across high-footfall locations:

- Campus activations: University of Johannesburg, Wits University, University of Pretoria, Stellenbosch University, CPUT, UKZN, Rosebank College, AFDA, Varsity College, and Monarch.
- Malls and retail activations: Campus Square, Sandton City, V&A Waterfront, Menlyn Mall, Hatfield Square, Rosebank Mall, Gateway Mall, Pavilion, and Paledi Mall.
- Student accommodation sites: Targeting high-density residences in Johannesburg, Pretoria, Cape Town, and Durban.

Promotion:
Promotional activities are designed to maximize engagement and social amplification:

- Influencer marketing: Collaborate with 2 Gen Z influencers for authentic brand storytelling on Instagram, TikTok, and X (Twitter).
- Experiential activations: Photobooths, and games at campuses, malls, and sponsored networking events.
- Social media campaigns: Use branded hashtags (#AddADegree, #TheGraduateMoment), social competitions, and user-generated content to encourage peer sharing.
- Event sponsorships: Engage with graduate networking events to provide photobooths, and exclusive experiences.
- Search engine and social boosting: Leverage paid campaigns on Instagram, TikTok, and Google to expand reach.

People:
Student brand ambassadors and event staff are trained to deliver immersive, high-energy experiences that align with the brand personality: playful, aspirational, stylish, and sociable.

Process:
Activations are streamlined to ensure seamless customer experiences, from registration at campus events to sample collection, social media posting, and post-event follow-ups.

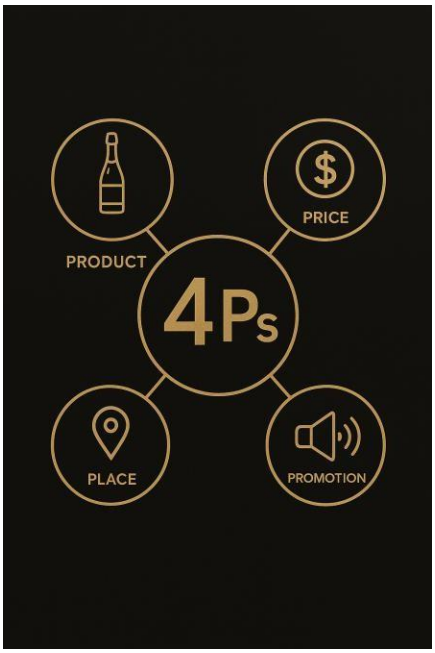
Physical Evidence:
The black-and-gold packaging, branded photobooths, and visually appealing activation setups

reinforce the premium and celebratory brand image, providing shareable moments for both online and offline audiences.

Innovation & Cultural Relevance

This strategy integrates digital culture, experiential marketing, and social validation-key drivers for Gen Z. The Big Idea encourages graduates to celebrate milestones in a way that is socially shareable, aspirational, and culturally resonant, differentiating *The Graduate* from established luxury brands such as Moët, Veuve Clicquot, and Dom Pérignon, which focus primarily on heritage and exclusivity rather than participatory celebrations.

By combining a thoughtful marketing mix with culturally relevant creative execution, *The Graduate* is positioned to become the go-to celebratory champagne brand for Gen Z graduates across South Africa, fostering both short-term engagement and long-term brand loyalty.



8) Campaign Tactics & Channel Plan

The Graduate campaign employs a multi-channel marketing approach tailored to the media consumption habits, social behaviors, and celebration culture of South African Gen Z graduates. Each channel is carefully selected to maximize engagement, brand visibility, and conversion.

1. Digital & Social Media Channels

- Instagram, TikTok, and X (Twitter): Primary platforms to reach Gen Z through short-form video content, reels, stories, and interactive polls. Social competitions using hashtags like #AddADegree and #TheGraduateMoment encourage user-generated content, fostering virality and peer-to-peer engagement.

- Paid social ads: Targeted paid campaigns based on age, interests, and campus location optimize reach and engagement. AI-driven content calendars schedule posts for peak interaction times.
- Search Engine Marketing (Google Ads): Keyword-targeted campaigns for “graduate celebrations,” “champagne for students,” and “student party ideas” ensure brand discovery by users actively searching for celebratory solutions.

2. Influencer Marketing

- Collaborate with 2 Gen Z influencers across Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube who embody the aspirational yet relatable personality of the brand. Influencers create content around graduation moments, unboxing experiences, and lifestyle celebrations featuring *The Graduate*.
- Micro-influencers at targeted campuses amplify authenticity, encouraging peer sharing and trust among students.

3. Experiential Marketing

- Campus Activations: Interactive booths with photobooths, drink tastings, and games at University of Johannesburg, Wits University, University of Pretoria, University of Limpopo, Stellenbosch University, CPUT, UKZN, Rosebank College, AFDA, Varsity College, and Monarch.
- Mall Activations: Sampling and experiential installations at Sandton City, Mall of Africa, V&A Waterfront, Menlyn Mall, Hatfield Square, Rosebank Mall, Gateway Mall, Pavilion, and Paledi Mall, focusing on high student foot traffic.
- Student Accommodation Activations: Targeted events in Johannesburg, Pretoria, Cape Town, and Durban, engaging students where they live to build intimate brand experiences.

4. PR & Sponsorships

- Graduate Networking Events: Sponsor and provide champagne sampling at student-focused networking events and ceremonies. Include photobooths and social media activations to amplify experiences online.
- Press Releases & Student Media: Partner with campus radio stations, student newspapers, and online publications to create pre-event buzz, highlighting the brand as the ultimate celebration choice.

5. Competitions & Engagement

- Social Media Competitions: Encourage students to share their graduation moments with *The Graduate* to win exclusive limited-edition packs or VIP experiences.
- Campus Challenges: Mini competitions during activations (e.g., best graduation outfit or dance challenge) generate real-time content that feeds into social media platforms.

9) Campaign Mock-ups & Prototypes



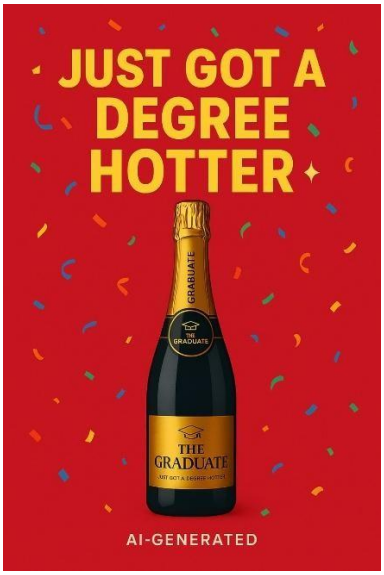
Bottle & Packaging Mock-up



Experiential Activation Mock-up



ORIGINAL



AI- GENERATED

10) Implementation Timeline & Budget

The Graduate campaign will be executed over a **six-month period (January 2026 – June 2026)**, targeting peak graduation and celebration periods in South Africa, including summer graduations (Dec–Feb), university events, and winter social activations. The phased roll-out ensures maximum visibility and engagement while optimizing spend.

Implementation Timeline

Month	Key Activities	Channels / Touchpoints
Jan 2026	Pre-launch digital teaser campaigns, influencer onboarding, AI-generated content creation	Social media (Instagram, TikTok, Facebook, X), Influencer platforms
Feb 2026	Campus activations kick-off (UJ, Wits, Pretoria, Limpopo), mall activations start, launch competitions	Campus booths, malls, social media, landing page
Mar 2026	Expansion to remaining campuses (Stellenbosch, CPUT, UKZN, AFDA, Rosebank, Varsity College, Monarch), continued mall activations	Campus activations, social campaigns, influencer posts
Apr 2026	Sponsored networking events, student accommodation activations, social media competitions peak	Event activations, social media, influencer amplification
May 2026	Consolidation of digital campaigns, evaluation of engagement metrics, targeted paid ads, continued mall activations	Social media, search engine marketing, events
Jun 2026	Closing campaigns, reporting, post-event follow-ups, UGC (user-generated content) recap, brand reinforcement	Social media recap, email, landing page

Budget Allocation (Total R100,000)

Category	Description	Budget (R)
Digital & Social Media	Paid ads on Instagram, TikTok, Facebook, X, YouTube; social media content creation using AI and Traditional media using radio and newspapers	22,000
Influencer Marketing	Fees for 3 Gen Z influencers, content creation, and campaign promotion	18,000
Campus Activations	Booths, photobooths, games, drink sampling, staff	13,000
Mall Activations	Event installations, sampling stations, branding	13,000
Student Accommodation Activations	Small-scale experiential events in high-density residences	9,000
PR & Sponsorships	Graduate networking events, press releases, student media partnerships	5,000
AI Tools/ Design Software	Canva AI, Jasper, Midjourney, Adobe Firefly subscriptions	5,000
Competitions & Engagement	Social media contest prizes, giveaways, limited- edition packs	5,000
Contingency 10%	Buffer for unexpected costs	10,000
Total		**100,000**

Objective	KPI	Target
Brand Awareness	Social media reach and impressions	500,000 total reach across Instagram, TikTok, Facebook, X
Engagement	Likes, shares, comments, hashtag usage (#AddADegree, #TheGraduateMoment)	50,000 engagements
Event Participation	Attendance at sponsored networking events and campus activations	5,000 attendees
Sales Conversion	Bottles sold via online and retail channels	1,500 units

Influencer ROI	Engagement per influencer post, reach vs. cost	Minimum 3:1 ROI per influencer

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